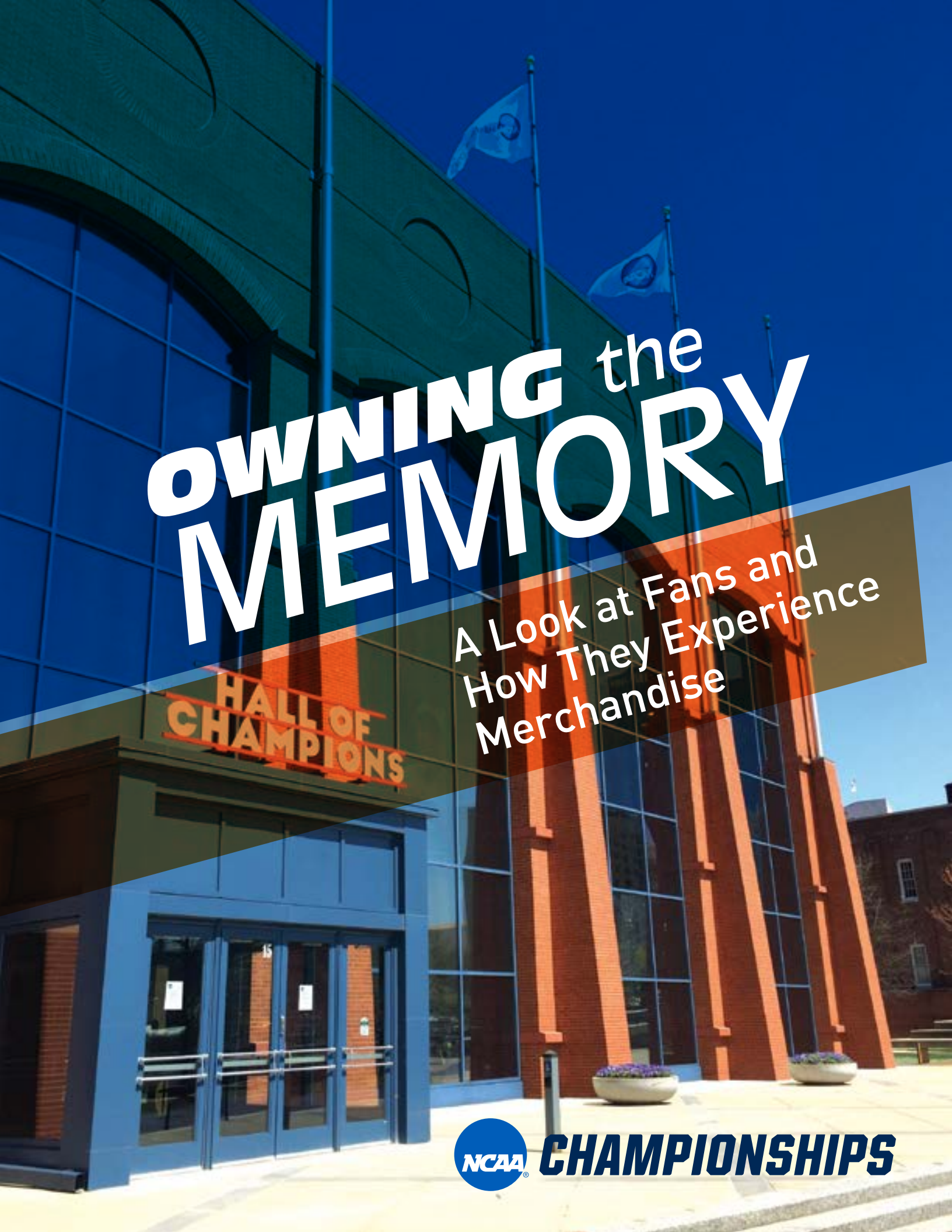


OWNING the MEMORY

A Look at Fans and How They Experience Merchandise

NCAA CHAMPIONSHIPS

TABLE OF CONTENTS

5 The Background
6 Methodology
7 Project Overview

8 SWIMMING
11 Introduction
13 Personas
23 Experience Flow
30 Customer Suggestions & Major Insights

32 BASKETBALL
35 Introduction
37 Personas
51 Experience Flow
56 Pain Point Summary & Major Insights
59 Finding Opportunities
63 Ideation Tool
67 Conclusion

BACKGROUND

The research conducted in this report was a partnership between the **NCAA** and **IUPUI graduate students in Design Thinking and Design Leadership at Herron School of Art and Design**. This project was part of a larger study of merchandise experience in collaboration with IUPUI graduate students from the School of Physical Education and Tourism Management. For both research teams the goal of this project was to understand the fan experience at the NCAA championships surrounding the merchandise, both quantitatively and qualitatively.

This report presents collected qualitative data from the **2016 NCAA DII Swimming and Diving Championship** and the **Women's Final Four Basketball Championship** events.

PROJECT PARTNERS

HERRON SCHOOL
of ART + DESIGN

This research was conducted as part of the course, **Collaborative Action Research in Design** for the MFA Degree in Visual Communication Design. In using different research methods we were able to gain an understanding of the fan experience and offer fan profiles and insightful findings with a people-centered design focus.

The Design Team: Linjun Chen, Wendy Hsu, Vesta Mohebbi, Miley Phillips, Jack Rong, Lisa Semidey, Ed Sieferd, Madison Stevens ***Professor:*** Youngbok Hong

Methodology

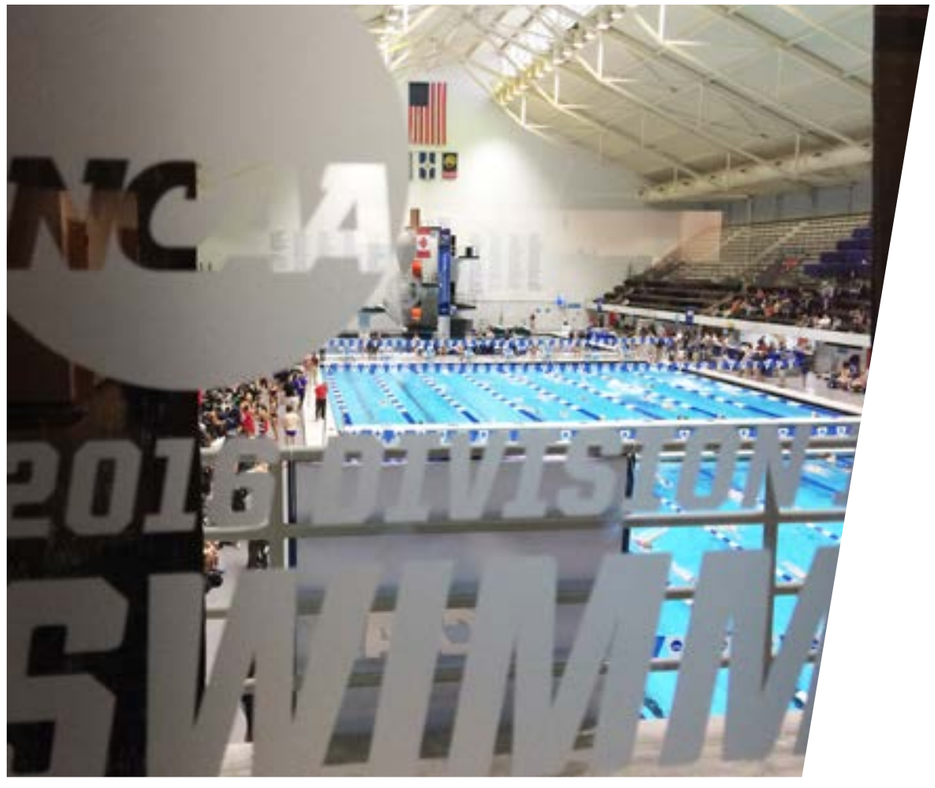
Design Thinking is a people-centered approach to innovative and collaborative problem solving. For this project, we adopted the perspective of NCAA championship attendees to understand their "merchandise experience" by using ethnographic interviews and observation research methods. These methods allowed us to gain a deeper understanding of the contextual reality surrounding people's experiences at championship events.

Once the data was collected from both swimming and basketball events, our design team went through an analysis and synthesis process for each data set to identify pain points and categorize major insights. Using a people-centered approach, we discovered an understanding related to customers' reasons and motivations for purchasing merchandise. By capturing the overall event experience, we were able to identify opportunities to enhance their merchandise experience by leveraging the different touchpoints along their journey.

Lastly, based on the participants' suggestions and our defined insights, we were able to develop strategic approaches to enhance the attendees' merchandise experiences by connecting their overall event experiences. The actual findings will be discussed throughout this report.



© Simplex: A Flight to Creativity, Min Basadur



Project Overview

This report is divided into two chapters based on our research; **NCAA Men and Women's DII Swimming and Diving**, and the **Women's Final Four Basketball Championships,** both held in Indianapolis, IN. We conducted research for the Swimming and Diving event at the IU Natatorium, and for the Final Four event at Tourney Town, the JW Marriott, and Bankers Life Fieldhouse. Our design research process took place over the course of 8 weeks and included insights from more than 50 participants between the two NCAA championships.

9»

SWIMMING

NCAA
2016 DIVISION II
SWIMMING & DIVING CHAMPIONSHIPS





INTRODUCTION

On March 10, 2016, our design research team conducted 20 interviews over the course of 3 days for the **NCAA DII Swimming and Diving Championship** in the **IU Natatorium at IUPUI**. To avoid influencing the customer's purchasing decision, we intercepted each participant at the point of purchase by offering a $25 dollar voucher in exchange for their participation in a 10-30 minute interview. Once the customer agreed, we used a question framework designed to first understand their overall journey, then identify their feelings at each touchpoint, and zoom into their merchandise experience. By conducting an interview following the flow of a conversation, people felt comfortable opening up to share their swimming experiences, purchasing motivations, and family stories.

This chapter will give insights into the swimming championship attendees by way of Personas and also describe their overall journey and merchandise experience in detail by way of an Experience Flow Map.





Photos courtesy of NCAA

PERSONAS

3 Days | 20 Interviews

Persona development is used as a method for categorizing people based on their character traits, interests, needs and goals. To help identify the different types of attendees at the 2016 DII Swimming & Diving championship, we developed personas to show the different aggregations of behavioral patterns and perceptions. To create each persona, we used the data acquired in the interview sessions to formulate four distinct profile types of the attendees who purchased merchandise. The profile types include: James Smith, an **Athlete Extraordinaire** (pg 16), Kira Baken, a **Prospective NCAA Swimmer** (pg 17), The Millers, **Family Cheerleaders with Participating Athlete** (pg 18), and Becky Brooks, **a Former Swimmer and Lifelong Fan** (pg 20).

Each persona profile includes the reason for attending, purchasing motivations, shopping assessments, and their merchandise experience suggestions.

1



James Smith
Athlete Extraordinaire

BACKGROUND

Age:
- 19

Travel details:
- Traveled by plane from San Diego, CA

Reason for attending:
- Competing in 4 Freestyle events

Times attending nationals:
- 1st NCAA championship as a sophomore

SHOPPING EXPERIENCE

Who is the purchase for?
- Purchased merch for himself

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased merch to commemorate his first NCAA competition & to show his achievement after event

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Prefers long sleeve t-shirts with simple designs

Shopping behavior:
- Purchased on first day to ensure he got his correct size & purchased available merch again on last day to have additional items

Overall assessment:
- Transaction was very easy limited options make the decision making process simple

SUGGESTION

Shopping preferences:
- Would like to see the merch by the pool to know what is available
- A booth with last minute items for sale around pool area would be helpful (i.e. caps, goggles)
- Would like to see same print on different color shirts instead of many prints on different colors
- Wants to see merch hung on wall or mannequin to visualize it better

2



Kira Baken
Prospective NCAA Swimmer

Age:
- 16

Travel details:
- Traveled by car from local area

Reason for attending:
- Comparing teams for future consideration

Times attending nationals:
- 1st Time attending DII Championship

Who is the purchase for?
- Purchased sweatshirt for herself

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased merch with year to remember her first NCAA experience

Overall assessment:
- She would have preferred a black sweatshirt

Shopping preferences:
- Would like to see a larger color variety

3



The Millers
Family Cheerleaders

Age:
- Mom-48, Dad-52, Son-24, Daughter-21

Travel details:
- Traveled by car from North Carolina

Reason for attending:
- Arrived for Daughter's last NCAA competition

Times attending nationals:
- 3rd NCAA championship as a senior

Who is the purchase for?
- Mom purchased for husband, daughter, grandparents, and self & Dad purchased for son

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased merch to support daughter & wear with pride after event

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Prefers merch with good quality

Shopping behavior:
- Purchased on the first, second, & last day

Overall assessment:
- Sales team was friendly and helpful Merchandise was well-laid out and easy to see Prices seemed cheaper than previous experiences

4



Becky Brooks
Former Swimmer / Lifelong Fan

Age:
35

Travel details:
- Traveled by car from local area

Reason for attending:
- Supporting a coach who is an old friend

Times attending nationals:
- Attends all local NCAA events when possible

Who is the purchase for?
- Purchased towel for herself

Reason for shopping:
- She typically always purchases merch at special events

Overall assessment:
- Believes towel & merch is too expensive for a Division II swimming event

1

James Smith

Athlete Extraordinaire



Age 19

BACKGROUND

James Smith is a 19 year old sophomore that swims for UC San Diego. He is originally from New Mexico, where he started swimming at the age of six. He flew in with his teammates on Sunday from California. They have been staying at the Marriott since their arrival and getting practice runs at the Natatorium since Monday. It has been a busy week for James. He is relieved to find out that his Mom and Dad will be supporting him during his first NCAA level swim meet. They flew in from New Mexico on Wednesday to see his first event. He is a freestyler and competed in the 100m, 200m, 400m relay and the 1650m races and earned top three finishes in most of the events. He couldn't be more excited to have competed at the IU Natatorium. So many incredible swimmers have competed in that pool, he feels honored to share in that experience. Saturday night was his only free night to be able to watch other events and support his UC San Diego teammates.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Since it is a huge deal to make it to the NCAA championship, he bought a long-sleeve t-shirt to commemorate that fact. He wants to wear the shirt after the event to show that he was there, competing at that level. He looked around the table briefly and ended up choosing the long-sleeve t-shirt because he liked the simple design on it. He was glad the shopping experience was short and simple so that he could get back to watch his friends swim the final events. He also bought a pull-over on the first day and continued to stop by briefly to see what other items were still available. By the end of the championship event, he knew he wanted another item to commemorate his experience so he purchased the long-sleeve shirt.

SUGGESTIONS

Although he appreciates a simple shopping experience, he has some ideas to improve it. First he would like to have a better display of t-shirts either on mannequins or hung up. It would be easier to see the merchandise and make a decision of what would looks good on him based on the cut. Secondly, it would be a good idea to have a merchandise display in the pool area so that athletes can see what is available during their limited time outside of the water. Lastly, it would be helpful to have an opportunity to purchase last minute items such as caps and goggles preferably inside the Natatorium. Many times those necessary items break or get lost, and he would feel more secure in knowing there are available options.

In terms of the designs of the merchandise, he would like to have fewer designs, but more color options per design. Sometimes he only likes one particular design but doesn't like the color it's printed on.

2

Kira Baken

Prospective NCAA Swimmer



Age 16

BACKGROUND

Kira and her friend Robin drove from the northwest side of Indianapolis to downtown right after school. Since the championship meets do not start until 6 p.m, they decided to go to the mall to shop around. Kira is excited to experience the IU Natatorium for the first time. All of her favorite swimmers have swam in that pool, and she cannot wait to swim in it one day as well. She has been swimming since the age of 7, and is now in her junior year of high school at North Central. Some of the colleges that she is considering are going to be swimming tonight, and she plans to observe the coaches and her potential future teammates to help make her decision. She enjoys going to local swim meets, but has never had the opportunity to experience a Division II NCAA championship.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Kira had planned on purchasing a sweatshirt to commemorate her experience at the championships. Even while she was at the mall, she saved her money in order to be able to have enough for a sweatshirt. While viewing the selection, a blue sweatshirt caught her eye. She felt the material and held it up to make sure it would fit properly. Normally she would choose a black sweatshirt, but since it was not offered she purchased the blue one anyway.

She cannot wait to go back to school tomorrow and show it off to her other swim teammates. She has many comfortable sweatshirts that she wears, but this one will be one of her favorites until her time comes to compete at the collegiate national level.

SUGGESTIONS

Her shopping experience was fast and convenient, but she still would like to have more color variety with the same designs, specifically black.

3

The Millers

Family Cheerleaders



Sarah, mom, 48; **Dave**, dad, 52; **Riley**, daughter, athlete competing, 21; **Keegan**, son, not able to attend competition, 24

BACKGROUND

The Millers are from North Carolina. Sarah and Dave drove 10 hours to Indianapolis with Sarah's parents to watch Riley compete in the 100m and 200m breaststroke events. They rented a house in the city because it is more spacious and comfortable during their week-long stay. This is Riley's 3rd NCAA championship, and Sarah and Dave have been to all three. However, this is a first for Sarah's parents, and they are very excited to experience this major event with their granddaughter. Their son Keegan had a regatta competition back in North Carolina, and unfortunately he had to miss his sister's competition.

As a family, the Millers enjoy a variety of outdoor activities. Often times they go hiking in the mountains or vacationing at their family cottage that sits on a lake. Many of their extracurricular activities involve being in or around water in some way. Keegan has been sailing since he was 10 and Riley has been swimming competitively since the age of 4.

Being able to experience Riley's last major competition with her is very sentimental. Sarah has been putting together a scrapbook of all of the memories from swimming over the years to give to Riley at the end of the year. Many of her photos are from her middle and high school swimming days, just because she is not as involved in Riley's college experience as she was in high school. Also it is difficult to capture images of the athletes while they are swimming because of the distance from the bleachers to the pool.

The entire family is very excited about being at the IU Natatorium. The pool area is beautiful and well ventilated, which is very important. Riley has been in some indoor facilities where she had to have an inhaler because of poor ventilation. Even as a spectator, Sarah and Dave have had some problems with air quality in some areas, but did not experience that at this natatorium.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Sarah purchased items when she arrived the first day and made additional purchases on the second day. The first day she purchased a dri-fit half zip for her husband, Dave; a v-neck t-shirt for herself; 2 cotton shirts for her parents; and a short-sleeve cotton shirt for Riley. When she arrived she wasn't able to see Riley because she was practicing in the pool area, so she took a guess at what she might like. She texted a picture of the half-zip pink sweatshirt, but then realized they only had large sizes left. When she finally saw her daughter, Riley told her she hadn't had a chance to check out the available merchandise but she actually wanted a long-sleeve shirt. The sales attendant was very friendly and told her to bring the shirt back tomorrow and he would exchange the short sleeve for a long sleeve if she paid the difference in price.

Dave purchased a shirt for Keegan toward the end of the week. He sent him a picture of the merchandise selection and asked him what he wanted. Usually Dave does not purchase for himself, he tends to buy whatever his kids want; which is easier than guessing what he thinks they want. The prices seem reasonable compared to other merchandise they've purchased at regional events in the past.

The Millers purchase merchandise to wear when they return home. The shirt reminds them of the memory of being at the event and also gives them a sense of pride for Riley. During the competition they wear shirts that support Riley's college. This shows support for their school but also makes it easier to meet other parents from the same school.

Sarah prefers cotton v-neck t-shirts. She and Riley do not like the dri-fit material unless it is in a half-zip mostly because it is too clingy. The cotton material is more breathable. Sarah liked the pink zip-up that was offered but Riley prefers neutral colors. Overall, Sarah likes the quality of the shirts. She typically buys Champion brand merchandise, and still wears the shirts she bought three years ago.

Dave is not a fan of crew-neck t-shirts. He mostly wears polos but the pullover half-zip sweatshirts are nice too. He and Keegan like the dri-fit materials typically.

SUGGESTIONS

Sarah would like the option to purchase items online. Many times the booth doesn't have the size or style that she would prefer so she buys items that would not be her best choice. Sarah and Dave also think it would be nice to be able to purchase professional photography online after the event is over. They saw a few professional photographers and thinks other parents might enjoy getting better quality images of their kids during the competition as a way to record memories.

4

Becky Brooks

Former Swimmer / Lifelong Fan



Age 35

BACKGROUND

Becky and her husband, Ray, drove to the Natatorium after work. They are local fans living on the south side of Indianapolis, IN. While Ray is a fan of any sport, Becky used to swim in college and has earned state recognition in the 200m butterfly event. Since then she has become a high school English teacher, where she attends and supports all of her school's swim events during the winter season. Some would call her a swimming enthusiast. She used to coach the high school team, but had to take some time off when her daughter was born five years ago. She still swims every week to stay fit. Many times she will take her daughter along with her to expose her to the water early, the way Becky's parents did for her when she was young.

She has been to a few NCAA swimming events specifically, but likes to attend major swim meets anytime they are hosted locally. Thankfully, Ray also enjoys the sport, because he accompanies her often. She is excited about this year's event because an old college teammate, who now coaches for Lindenwood University, is here with her athletes for the first time.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Ray likes to joke that Becky lives by the phrase "been there, got the t-shirt". She enjoys purchasing souvenirs at events because she is reminded of the great memories she experienced. Although her drawers overflow with old special event t-shirts, that doesn't stop her from purchasing more.

In terms of materials and design, the quick dry and colorful cotton t-shirts are her favorite ones. This time she bought a towel, because it is useful and has the 2016 NCAA logo. Although she likes the design, it may be too expensive for a division II event, the price seems more suitable for the Olympic trials. She likes many of the t-shirts designs, but could not find a long sleeve t-shirt in a smaller size.

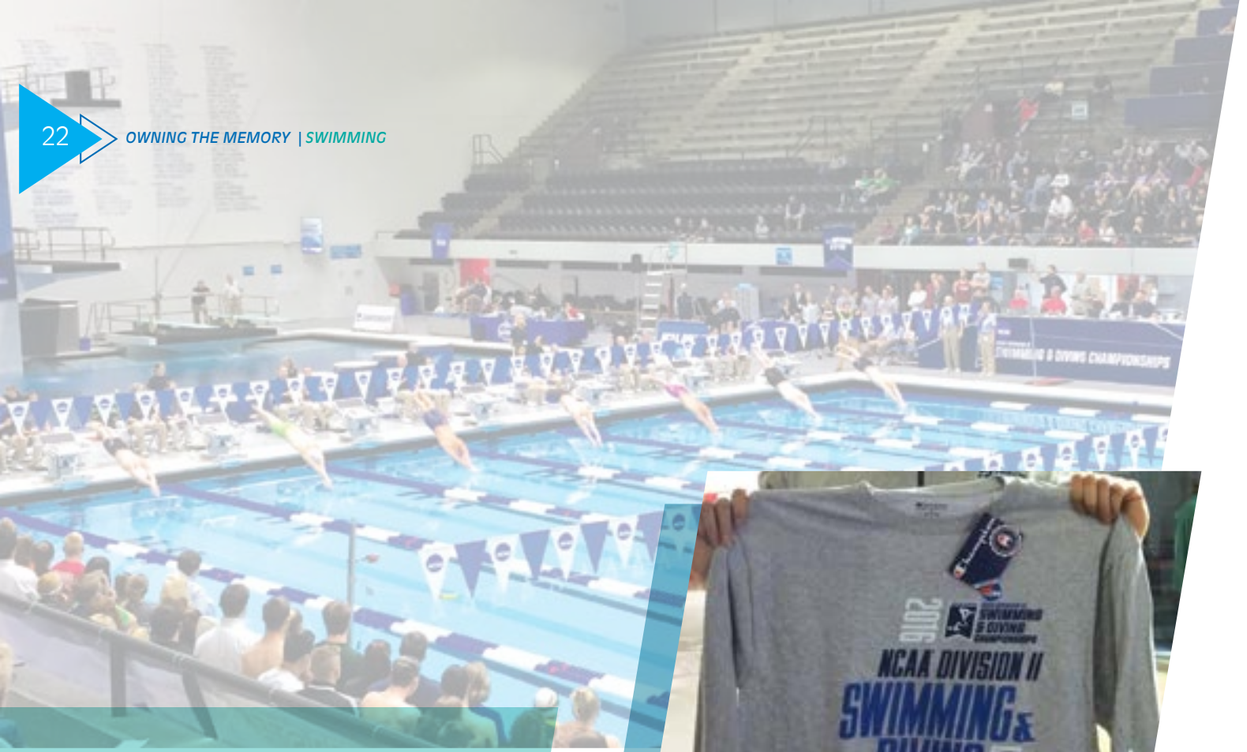
SUGGESTIONS

Becky's first concern was finding an entry-priced item below $25. Because she is not here supporting an athlete specifically, she would like a small memento of her experience, but does not want to spend $50 to get one. Also, moving the booth closer to the entrance would bring more attention to the merchandise because of the large flow of people walking through. Lastly, cleaning up the construction in the hallway could help the booth not feel as dark and uninviting.





Class discussion while developing personas and experience flow maps for the DII Swimming and Diving Championship.









EXPERIENCE FLOW

An **Experience Flow Map** illustrates the overall journey of the attendees while describing the activity and emotions throughout the event. Our design research team developed the map based on the interview data we gathered at the IU Natatorium where we asked participants to describe their touchpoints in detail. Each touchpoint on the map highlights the pain points and insights the fans experienced during their journey.

The Overall Experience Flow map shows the fans' experiences from the time they leave their home to the time they finish the DII Swimming and Diving event. The Athlete and Non-athlete Shopping Experience maps provide a closer look at the purchasing opportunities between the two types of customers. Athletes are those that are swimming in the championship competition and Non-athletes consist of supporting family members and spectator fans.

LEAVE FROM HOME

Pain Point
- Possible flight delay
- Unfamiliar with transportation system in new city

Interest
- Confirming accommodation

Suggestion
- Include all the transportation, parking, touring sites, hotel, merchandise related in online communication with ticket buyers
- Provide a comprehensive info package
- Consolidate all the communication channels included

TRAVEL

Pain Point
- Tired after long travel time
- Unfamiliar with City

Interest
- Finding restaurants and public transportation

Suggestion
- Provide transportation, parking, tourism, merchandise related event information at partnered hotels

ARRIVE AT HOTEL

ARRIVE AT VENUE

Pain Point
- Not knowing where to enter the natatorium
- Difficulty parking at natatorium
- Too many tickets

Emotion
- Excitement for child's accomplishment
- Excitement for the athletic event

Activity
- Find ticket booth
- Attend swim meet
- Buy swim schedules

Suggestion
- For NCAA staff or vendors, to have more active interaction to assist fans
- Streamline to one ticket passport, easier to carry

Additional Activities

Dine Out | Rest | Explore Indianapolis

Purchase Opportunity

ARRIVE TO WATCH MORNING COMPETITIONS

LEAVE FROM VENUE

Interest
- Finding a preferred restaurant

Purchase Opportunity

ARRIVE TO WATCH EVENING COMPETITIONS

Emotion
- Excitement for child's accomplishments
- Excitement for the athletic event

Activity
- Find ticket booth
- Attend swim meet

LEAVE FROM VENUE

Emotion
- Athlete's sentiment for the game attending

Activity
- Last minute for athletes to shop

RETURN TO HOTEL

TOUCHPOINTS	ACTIONS	FEELING	INTERACTION	OBJECT	MOTIVATION FOR PURCHASE
ARRIVAL	• Comes with team on bus	• Feel excitement for personal milestone in swimming career • Excited for attending competition at the significant venue for swimming – the IU Natatorium • Enthusiastic for coming here with peers • Inspired by seeing other competitors/coaches • Appreciate the high quality of IUPUI indoor swimming pools and environment, boosted their confidence and performance • Athletes who consider this their last swimming meet might be more sentimental • Consider the event very organized • Alternates feel left out by getting a souvenir bag as other competitors		• Competitors receives a goodie bag included various souvenirs • Competitors like the souvenir jacket the got from the event	
SEEK OUT BOOTH	PAIN POINT • Asks others for the booth's location	PAIN POINT • Feels like they cannot see the full selection of merchandise because of booth location outside of pool area	PAIN POINT • Some people couldn't find the merchandise booth because they came in with different entrance		• Keeps an eye on merchandise since arriving to event
INTERACT W/ MERCHANDISE	• Browses booth when passing by •Comes with friends to find desired items. •They didn't travel with family but with team	• Excited to see merchandise with simple designs	PAIN POINT • Wishes the merchandise was hung on the rod which would help the buyer to visualize wearing it	PAIN POINT • Didn't have the color they preferred • Values variety of color options • Likes the ability to clearly read the logo	
MAKE PURCHASE DECISION		• Feels pressed for time to make purchase because of swimming schedule • Sense of pride drives item selection		• Emphasized design over color and material preference	• Usually buys for themselves, sometimes for family too
MAKE PURCHASE	• Buys for themselves • Tell their parents to purchase desired items		• Some make muliple purchases throughout the event after taking time to think about their items of interest	• Likes to have parents purchase the items separately	• Purchases merchandise as a memento for the event

NCAA DII Swimming & Diving > **Non-Athlete Shopping Experience**

TOUCHPOINTS	ACTIONS	FEELING	INTERACTION	OBJECT	MOTIVATION FOR PURCHASE
ARRIVAL		PAIN POINT • Experiences frustration about parking instructions • Excited to support teammates & family • Excited to experience national championship • Feels nostalgic of former swim career • Likes natatorium air quality and facility	PAIN POINT • Parking structure has been confusing	• Always looking for more information about restaurant or parking, would like to have pamphlet about it	
SEEK OUT BOOTH	• Looks for merchandise to buy • Asks friends or Natatorium staff for location	PAIN POINT • Some people are confused because they could not find the merchandise booth because they came in through a different entrance	PAIN POINT • Asked others for booth's location		• They always want to buy merchandise at each event
INTERACT W/ MERCHANDISE	• Glances at the merchandise display while passing by several times • People cross the white barrier to reach the booth • Looks for interesting merchandise • Learns about product • Touches or feels the merchandise	PAIN POINT • The unfinished and dark environment of booth location does not encourage people to stay longer at the concourse area	PAIN POINTS • No mannequin, people need to pick up the shirt to see the design for front and back side • Would like to see bigger or clear price tag • Wants the lighting of the merchandise area to be brighter • Staff is sitting or standing behind the table, not engaging with passerby • Thinks the table layout and price assortment and price is good • Wants to have an online shopping website to order afterward	• Thinks t-shirt and swimming towel are appropriate merchandise for swimming • Looks for branding products	• Some families always purchase t-shirts when they go to championship events
MAKE PURCHASE DECISION	**FAMILY** • Tries to guess which merchandise their athlete child will appreciate • Texts child the image of the merchandise for confirmation • Makes purchase according to child's desire	**FAMILY** • Family buys merchandise for athlete as a gift and for memory and something for themselves as a memento of their attendance • Believes some designs are too complicated • Glad that booth still has certain sizes for sale	**FAN** PAIN POINT • Only can see the items from the booth, no alternative option	**FAMILY** PAIN POINT • The popular design run out of sizes quickly • Moms considers the quality of clothing, the material needs to be durable for washing and not to wrinkle • Looking for the "year" or "tournament name" on the t-shirt • More color selection for the same design • Would be interested to see more practical product options, such as a card-holder, seat cushion, bag, backpack or swim-related items • Wants to see more design option for long-sleeve t-shirts • Considers towel size is good for athlete to use as memento **FAN** PAIN POINT • Considers the towel too expensive for a DII competition • Likes to buy shirts • Athletic fans want to see sweatpants, sweatshirts, hats and t-shirts • Bought the towel because it has the event logo • Liked the material of towel	**FAN** • Always wants to buy something from the event for themselves for memento and record of attendance
MAKE PURCHASE	• Might come back to exchange merchandise for what their athlete child really wants	• Wants to wear the shirt to show pride and support the athlete afterward	PAIN POINT • Sometimes booth staff accept prodcut exchanges if done in a timely manner • Many people return to make additional purchases during competition		• Only wears items after tournament • Team apparel creates connection with other fan or parents

Customer Suggestions

- Include resource information regarding transportation, parking, tourist sites, hotels, and available merchandise in online communication prior to arrival
- Provide a comprehensive information package for fans upon arrival to event
- Consolidate all communication channels
- Provide non local attendees resources such as transportation and tourist sites at partnered hotels
- Train NCAA staff and vendors to have more of an active interaction to assist fans with questions and wayfinding
- Provide a ticket resource that streamlines all events into one package or passport to avoid fans carrying multiple ticket printouts
- An option to purchase merchandise online would allow customers to have a larger selection of color and size options
- A merchandise display by the pool would allow swimmers to see what is available and purchase merchandise during their limited time outside of the pool
- A booth with last minute items for sale such as goggles and swim caps in the natatorium area would be helpful for competing athletes
- Have the same printed design in a variety of colors would allow customers to not compromise style for color or color for their favorite design
- Place merchandise on a mannequin or hung on the wall to visualize better
- Include more entry level priced items less than $25
- Larger color variety

Summary of Ideas

NON-ATHLETE

Arrival

> Suggest the tickets be streamlined to a passport

> Will wear last year's event shirt to this year's event to show pride

Seek Out the booth

> Some people particularly intend to buy merchandise at the first day for better selection

Interact with Merchandise

> Parents might be interested in buying athlete's picture through online service

> Wished to have mannequin or staff wear or hang the t-shirts

Makes Decision to Buy

> Parents might have not been able to see their kid since arriving

> Some parents postpone their purchasing until they figure out whether it's a positive memory according to athlete's performance

Buy Merchandise

> Purchase multiple items at different times during the tournament

> Swimmers do not wear event shirt until after the event is over

ATHLETE

Arrival

> Will wear last year's event shirt to this year's event to show pride

Seek Out the booth

> Athletes wish the merchandise booth was located downstairs where athletes spend most of their time.

> May wants to buy last-minute items (like goggles)

Makes Decision to Buy

> Want lower price point items because they are still students

Buy Merchandise

> Competitors had limited time for shopping during the event

29 »

BASKETBALL





Photos courtesy of NCAA

INTRODUCTION

On April 1, 2016, our design research team conducted research over the course of two days during the **Women's Final Four** basketball tournament in three of the areas where merchandise was being sold; **Tourney Town**, the **JW Marriott**, and **Bankers Life Fieldhouse**. Using a question framework designed to understand the fans' experiences through merchandise and a $25 voucher incentive, we conducted interviews with 30 participants. We expanded the questions beyond their shopping experience to understand where they came from, what family traditions they may have, and how we could enhance their overall merchandise experience.

This chapter provides an understanding of the people who attend the Women's Final Four championship events by way of Personas, describes their overall journey and merchandise experiences in detail by way of Experience Flow Maps, and provides a tool to generate ideas to improve the merchandise experience based on a people-centered approach.



(Above) Tamika Catchings interacts with fans at Tourney Town event on Friday afternoon.
(Below) Fans arrive to Tourney Town.

PERSONAS

2 Days / 30+ Interviews

Persona development is used as a method for categorizing people based on their character traits, interests, needs and goals. To distinguish the different types of Final Four attendees, we utilized a persona development method similar to the swimming event where each persona profile includes the reason for attending, purchasing motivations, shopping assessments, and their merchandise experience suggestions. The basketball personas had a larger scope of fans and yielded seven distinctly different profiles. Three of the profiles fall under the category of occupational attendees who are there for work, and four of the persona profiles fall under the recreational attendees who are there to enjoy the event. The occupational profiles include: **NCAA Administrator** (pg 38), **Tourney Town Booth Vendor** (pg 38), a **non-NCAA coach** (pg 39), and an **In State Volunteer** (pg 39). The recreational profiles include: **Out of State Super Fans** (pg 40), **Out of State Family** (pg 40), and a **Sports Enthusiast** (pg 41).

OCCUPATIONAL BACKGROUND

SHOPPING EXPERIENCE

SUGGESTION

1



Sarah Connors

NCAA Administrator

Age:
- 35

Travel details:
- Flew in with close friend & staying at JW Marriott

Reason for attending:
- Working and attending meetings as a DII Admin but also brought close friend to accompany her to games

Type of fan:
- Returning attendee
- Played basketball from childhood into college. Enjoys supporting women's basketball & the sense of community it attracts

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased long sleeve t-shirt for friend to show appreciation for accompanying her to event
- Also a nap sack for her niece back home who loves to receive gifts from travels

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Her friend frequently purchases long sleeve t-shirts and has a large collection
- She saw the nap sacks on someone else and thought it'd be a unique gift from a t-shirt

Shopping behavior:
- Price conscious so always asks about price before making purchase

Overall assessment:
- Transaction was very easy, limited options make the decision making process simple

Shopping preferences:
- Would like to see DII & DIII shirts available

2



Regina Antone

Booth Vendor

Age:
- 30

Travel details:
- Commutes 1 hour from Bloomington, IN with coworkers

Reason for attending:
- Working a booth recruiting future Marine applicants

Type of fan:
- Returning vendor
- No team preference but enjoys coming to Final Four events to experience the energy

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased a team specific t-shirt for her UConn friend back home. She enjoys bringing back gifts for her loved ones that don't get to attend these events

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Price conscious when selecting gifts and prefers to buy items that are functional such as apparel

Shopping behavior:
- Purchased on the first day, but plans on purchasing more later
- Typically shops online to compare prices and items but would prefer to try on clothing before purchasing

Overall assessment:
- Likes how easy it was to interact with merchandise and friendly staff

Shopping preferences:
- Likes to purchase workout apparel like jackets, cotton sweat bands, and hair ties
- Would suggest having clear signage about direction of merchandise booths

3



Beth White

Non-NCAA coach

Age:
- 40

Travel details:
- Drove from Arkansas by herself

Reason for attending:
- Came for WCBA convention. Likes to attend these events to form professional relationships & learn from other coaches to improve her coaching

Type of fan:
- Returning attendee
- Enjoys watching all women's basketball including professional and collegiate
- Likes to support women athletics

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased items for her daughter who plays basketball & wants to bring back a memento for her to share in the experience

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Usually selects t-shirts because her daughter can wear the regularly

Shopping behavior:
- Looks for lower priced items because she is on a budget, may buy a shirt or a pin for herself depending on how much money she has toward the end

Overall assessment:
- Felt that the store was overpriced but liked the selection of the items available

Shopping preferences:
- Lower priced items to purchase gifts and small mementos without breaking her budget

4



Bill Stark

In-State Volunteer

Age:
- 65, male

Travel details:
- Drove back and forth from Crawfordsville, IN 3 hours away

Reason for attending:
- Volunteering to help give tourist resources and promote the city of Indianapolis

Type of fan:
- Returning volunteer
- No specific team preference, but loves watching all sports specifically supporting those hosted in Indianapolis

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased a small lapel pin as a small reminder of event

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Wanted something small and not highly priced so selected between a hat for golfing or a lapel pin

Shopping behavior:
- Typically shops for apparel that is comfortable at the mall but mostly shops in athletic stores

Overall assessment:
- Would have liked to see more smaller options to choose from
- Staff was friendly for him, but witnessed other customers frustrations with inexperienced check-out staff

Shopping preferences:
- Would like clearer prices on smaller items (magnets, hats, pins, bear, etc)

5



Mary, Jodey, Diana & Kate

Out of State Family

BACKGROUND

Age:
- 40-50 years old female friends

Travel details:
- Each friend flew in from different parts of the country
- One friend coordinated all travel details

Reason for attending:
- UConn alumni who travel to the Women's Final Four each year as a friend vacation and college reunion

Type of fan:
- Returning attendees
- Some are former UConn basketball players so considers themselves "huge" UConn fans

SHOPPING EXPERIENCE

Reason for shopping:
- Each fan purchased mementos such as stylish apparel for themselves & teddy bears & pins for loved ones

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Less concerned about price & prefer stylish merchandise items that they can wear to classier sports bars

Shopping behavior:
- Always purchases new UConn merchandise each year

Overall assessment:
- Good selection of quality materials but would have liked to see some of the old items from previous years available like the full zip sweatshirt

SUGGESTION

Shopping preferences:
- Would like an easier way to share tickets prior to event
- Would like more stylish options to choose from since they wear their apparel everywhere. A chambray button down would be nice

6



The Williams

Out of State Family

Age:
- Mom and dad: 40-50 / Little girl: 12 (Athlete) / Older girl: 15 (Super fan)

Travel details:
- Drove from Decatur, IL because flight prices were too expensive. Used tax return check to cover trip

Reason for attending:
- Youngest daughter is playing in middle school basketball tournament
- Family is generational fans, mom played college ball and oldest daughter plays in high school

Type of fan:
- First time attendees
- Defined themselves as "basketball junkies"

Reason for shopping:
- Purchased shirts for each daughter so they remember the experience & they will wear the t-shirts back to school to show they were there

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Parents are price conscious so only purchase one item for each daughter and do not get items for themselves

Shopping behavior:
- Typically like to look for bargains & shop online or use smart phones for shopping

Overall assessment:
- Prices were too high for the family to purchase as many items as they would have liked, but thought that there was a great variety to choose from

Shopping preferences:
- Would like to have option to shop online
- Daughters would like to have youth sizes represented

7



Frank Stella

Out of State Sports Enthusiast

Age:
- 55-65 male

Travel details:
- Traveled alone and staying in the downtown area

Reason for attending:
- Has a deep connection with sports & comes to the events as a way to stay connected to athletics & people he admires. He enjoys sports in general and has no preference on the particular event he is primarily interested in

Type of fan:
- Sports enthusiast

Reason for shopping:
- Likes to purchase collector items for himself and gifts for friends and family. Memorabilia holds significant value to him, provides him with a connection to a community

Purchasing decisions (item preference):
- Likes to buy items that have high interest for others and purchases many lower cost items for himself to add to his collection

Shopping behavior:
- Travels to each location to know what items are available

Overall assessment:
- Think the event merchandise is good but would like more smaller items he could get autographed
- Does not like the use of non-photographic posters for the signing sessions.

Shopping preferences:
- Would like to know which items are available at each location so he does not have to travel to all to see merchandise selection

1

Sarah Connors

NCAA Administrator



Age 35

BACKGROUND

Sarah flew into Indianapolis yesterday from Virginia. She is staying at the JW Marriott with one of her friends, Melissa. Sarah and Melissa have both loved basketball since they were little. Sarah grew up playing basketball since age six, and went on to play in college at the University of Charleston. From there she coached college basketball for thirteen years and now works for the NCAA as a Division II Administrator. While she is at the tournament for work, attending meetings in between the games, she enjoys the sport so much she wanted to bring a friend to share in the fun. This event is both work and play for her. The women's basketball community is a close one, she enjoys interacting with other coaches and old players. Sarah feels like this sense of community is what draws the fans, they like interacting with coaches and famous players who are more accessible than men's basketball.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Sarah purchased gifts for her two nieces back home in Virginia, and a shirt for her friend Melissa to show her appreciation for coming with her on this trip. Melissa usually attends the Final Four tournaments when she can, and always collects long sleeve t-shirts as a memento. Sarah purchased a blue long sleeve shirt for Melissa, and two sacks for her nieces. Sarah saw someone else at Tourney Town with the sack and thought it'd be a good gift, different than the usual t-shirts. Sarah asked about the price and size when making the purchase, but let Melissa choose the color and design. They both enjoyed the ease of transactions and friendly staff.

SUGGESTIONS

Sarah enjoys the way the tournament is organized in Indianapolis. She appreciates that everything is within walking distance and easy to find. Since Sarah attends the tournaments every year she has a unique understanding of the different locations and venues. She thinks the freebies at Tourney Town are a good way to get the community involved. Regarding the merchandise stand, she likes the long table set-up and the only thing she would like to be different is for the Division II and Division III teams to be included. Shirts with those teams would be nice to have. Sarah also asked about the lapel pins, but they did not have them on display yet.

2

Regina Antone

Booth Vendor



Age 30

BACKGROUND

Regina is a Recruitment Officer for the Marines. She commutes from Bloomington for 1-2 hours to work at the booth at the Final Four for the whole week. She has a group of coworkers who came with her this time. Her main job during the event is to screen every Marine applicant and supervise her co-workers for recruitment. She wears her Marine uniform during the working hours.

She is approximately 5'4" tall and has an athletic figure. She works out often and watches the NCAA basketball on TV usually. Although she won't be able to watch any Final Four games this year since she will have limited personal time while working at the event, she still enjoys being at the Final Four venue to experience the energy and excitement from the people and the event.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Since her buddy is from the hometown of one of the Final Four teams, she thought it would be really nice to buy something from the event and bring it back to her friend as a gift.

When she entered the Convention Center on the first morning of the event, she was already keeping an eye out for the merchandise booth. Her co-worker told her that she already passed the booth earlier while she was talking with someone else and didn't see it. Regina came back to the booth after she finished her work on the first day.

She bought a specific team t-shirt and only picked the team color because that way she couldn't go wrong to meet her buddy's preference. She thought about getting a baseball cap because the price is lower than the shirt. However, since her friend's hair is considerably thick and big, she didn't want to risk it not fitting.

When Regina wants to buy something, she wants to own it immediately. So buying that t-shirt for her friend was a one-time visit to the booth since she already decided to buy a t-shirt before her visit. However, when she buys these similar products for herself, she prefers to check online to learn about what the reasonable price would be first, then goes to the shop to purchase it. She thinks clothes look good on the mannequin, but don't necessarily look good on her. Everyone's body is different, so she definitely tries on the products before she buys.

She would be interested in coming back to check the booth again and pick something out for herself if she has time.

SUGGESTIONS

She prefers products that she can use while working out, such as jackets, cotton sweat bands to wipe sweat, and hair ties for women. Regina also suggests to have clear signage about the direction of the merchandise booth in the hallway. A stand-up sign people would run into and notice would be better than a poster on the wall.

3

Beth White

Non-NCAA coach



Age 40

BACKGROUND

Beth is a NAIA coach from Arkansas. She has been involved in athletics since she was young. Having been a student athlete she feels women's sports provides opportunities for personal development. She believes that as a former athlete, she needs to help others access those same opportunities she had as a student. She drove 10 hours to Indianapolis and is staying at the airport hotel. After arriving in Indianapolis she checked in to her hotel. She does a lot of traveling for her job, primarily recruiting and talking to prospective students. However, she does not often travel as far as she did for this trip. Beth came to the tournament after attending the WBCA convention and spent most of the week networking with other institutions. Her school is not paying for her trip, but it will reimburse her later. This is not her first time to the Final Four, but she only is able to see the event every few years when she attends the WBCA conference.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Beth mainly looks for items to buy her children. Beth's daughter is a big college sports fan and her daughter's favorite team was in the tournament, so she wanted to get her a t-shirt as a treat. Beth often tries to get items that her daughter can wear regularly. She does not often buy for herself, but she sometimes buys a shirt pin to remember the event. Beth does feel that the items are a little overpriced, so she only buys a few things that her family might like.

SUGGESTIONS

Beth liked the overall selection of items and enjoyed the variety. However, she would like to see lower priced items. While she's there, she would like to balance getting something for her family and keeping a budget.

4

Bill Stark

In-State Volunteer



Age 65

BACKGROUND

Bill has lived in Indiana his whole life, excluding when he served in the army. He is a retired real estate agent and his hobbies now include golf and reading. Bill drove 3 hours from where he lives in Crawfordsville to volunteer for the Women's Final Four event. He has always had an interest in sports and played basketball and baseball at IU. He decided to volunteer when he got an email from the Indy Sports Corporation and thought it would be a fun way to give back and promote the City of Indianapolis. Bill won't be attending any of the games, but enjoys walking around Tourney Town and assisting the fans with questions and directions. Now that he has more free time he likes to meet new people and get involved. Bill doesn't really have a team he supports, he is just proud of his city and wants to help. He knows Indianapolis fairly well from when he worked in real estate, and occasionally used to meet his son for dinner downtown when he was living here. His son has married and moved to North Carolina now. Bill enjoys being a part of the sporting event and meeting the fans. He parked in the assigned volunteer lot. A shuttle then took him to his assigned station at Tourney Town where he will work for 3 hours as a "runner" helping get items and assisting fans. After his shift he may walk around downtown and get dinner, then take the shuttle back to the lot to drive home.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Bill usually shops at the mall, mostly at athletic stores like Dick's Sporting Goods. He likes wearing athletic gear, but mostly just wants to be comfortable. He also shops online because stores usually don't have his size. He comes from a tall, athletic family and so shopping online makes it easier to get the right size. He decided to buy a lapel pin for himself. He wanted a small reminder of the event and volunteering. He considered getting a hat that he would use for golf, and looked at the two color options- gray and orange.

SUGGESTIONS

Bill would like to see clearer prices on some of the smaller items. Since he doesn't want to spend too much and just wants a small reminder, he wanted to know the prices for the smaller things including the lapel pins, hats, mugs, and magnets. The prices for these items aren't displayed as clearly as the apparel. Bill also witnessed a frustrated guest when they were making a purchase. He saw the cashier made a mistake when using the credit card machine, the software didn't work, and the guest was standing there a long time waiting for it to work. The cashier tried it three times and told the guest that his credit card wasn't working. The man asked the cashier volunteer if she was pressing "credit." She tried again and then the card worked. The guest shouldn't have waited that long for the volunteer to figure out the machine. Even though it didn't happen to Bill directly, he would have been frustrated by that situation. Maybe the cashier volunteers should be better trained.

5

Mary, Jodey, Diana & Kate

Out of State Super Fans



Mary Rover, 48; **Jodey Potter**, 48; **Diana Johnson**, 49; **Katherine (Kate) Hughes**, 46

BACKGROUND

Mary, Jodey, Diana, and Kate are good friends from college. They are alumni from the University of Connecticut and they each flew into Indianapolis to see their alma mater in the Final Four. Mary, Diana, and Kate played basketball for the UConn team in the late 1980's, before the team became renowned for winning. They consider themselves "basketball junkies" who love the sport and came to show support and cheer on the team. They didn't have as much support when they played, so it's important to them to support women's athletics. Jodey didn't play basketball in college, but she played in high school. After graduating, Mary went on to coach basketball at a junior college in Connecticut. Jodey moved to San Francisco and recently married her long-time partner Patricia. Jodey works as a TV producer, and is a big proponent for LGBT and womens' rights. Diana lives near Chicago and started her own business distributing athletic gear to vendors. Kate is an OBGYN and her husband a cardiologist. Although Mary, Jodey, Diana, and Kate all live across the country, they always find time to meet every year for the Women's Final Four. The trip is a getaway vacation for them to reunite their friendships and remember the glory days in celebrating women's basketball.

Mary always coordinates and plans the trip each year. They all meet up at the UConn hotel, the Omni Severin. At night they go out for drinks and wear old UConn athletic gear to show their team pride. While out, they meet other UConn fans. Since they don't know Indianapolis very well, they take a cab most everywhere they go.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Since each of the women are more affluent, they are less concerned about price. They each buy a shirt for themselves to remember the event on the first day they arrive. All of the ladies choose their shirt based on the quality and most stylish design, the most expensive options. When they go to Tourney Town Jodey and Diana decide to get Under Armour jackets since the weather was colder than expected. Kate got a basketball, and two teddy bears as gifts for her children. On the last day Kate also purchased t-shirts for everyone in her family, and Mary purchased a lapel pin as an added memento. She collects the pins every year.

SUGGESTIONS

Overall each of the ladies enjoyed the event. They like catching up, and meeting other UConn fans over the weekend. They like Indianapolis because everyone is friendly, but wished that there were more transportation options. The only main frustration was that it was hard to purchase and share the tickets. Mary had to purchase everyone's tickets together, and then had to hold on to them until they met up at the hotel. It would be better if tickets could be bought separately or shared more easily online, since each of them come from different parts of the country.

6

The Williams

Out of State Family



Linda, mom, 41; **Richard**, dad, 45; **Margaret**, daughter, 15; **Jenny**, daughter, 12

BACKGROUND

The Williams traveled together to attend the Women's Final Four as a weekend vacation and to compete in a local basketball tournament. Linda is a stay at home mom now, but played IU basketball in college. Richard is not very interested in sports and is there just to support their daughters, Margaret and Jenny. Margaret is the oldest daughter at the age of 15 and she is a super fan, she loved hearing about her mom's basketball glory days when she was younger. The youngest daughter, Jenny, is 12 years old and she is an enthusiastic athlete. She plays basketball, volleyball, and softball. The family came to Indianapolis because Jenny is playing in a middle school basketball tournament and it is their first time being at the Final Four. They all drove together from Decatur, Illinois and used their tax return for the whole trip. They are staying at the Holiday Inn hotel and are excited to go sightseeing at the Indianapolis Zoo and NCAA Hall of Champions.

PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Linda and Richard usually use their smartphones for online shopping. They buy souvenirs and gifts for their daughters while at the Final Four because the girls usually "trick" them into it. They are conscious about the prices, but Jenny and Margaret will choose what they like and what to buy, and then Richard will provide the credit card to purchase. They like buying t-shirts to wear back at school to show they were at the Final Four. Jenny will wear her shirt at her next basketball practice.

SUGGESTIONS

The Williams would like to have the option to purchase the merchandise online. Margaret checked ahead of time and there was more selection and variety of designs at the event than online. Jenny also wanted to buy a teddy bear and basketball, but because the prices were too high Richard only purchased the t-shirt for her. Since there were no youth sizes, even the small shirt was a little too big for Jenny. Along with youth sizing, they would have liked it if the prices were more reasonable or if more freebies were offered for attending the games.

7

Frank Stella

Out of State Sports Enthusiast



Age 55-65

BACKGROUND

Frank has been a sports fan for most of his life and he has fond memories of attending events as a child. Growing up he was an avid Red Sox fan and would attend their games with his father. He liked to collect baseball cards of his favorite players. As he grew up he started to become more involved in sports. He played high school basketball because he enjoyed the environment of having comradery and involvement with the community. Though Frank never played sports after high school he stayed involved in sports by attending games and spent time as a high school coach while he worked in sales. Now that he is retired, he dedicates a lot of his time to attending the national championships. During the spring and summer he travels to as many events as he can. He will often attend football, basketball and baseball events. He does not mind traveling to each event and likes to see the different cities. When he travels he likes to stay in the downtown area because most of the restaurants are within walking distance. While attending these events he enjoys meeting the players and coaches of the teams the most. At the event he spends a lot of time in the autograph lines waiting for his opportunity to have items signed. After he leaves the events he places the items in his display room. For Frank tickets and programs from the event are a great way to remember.

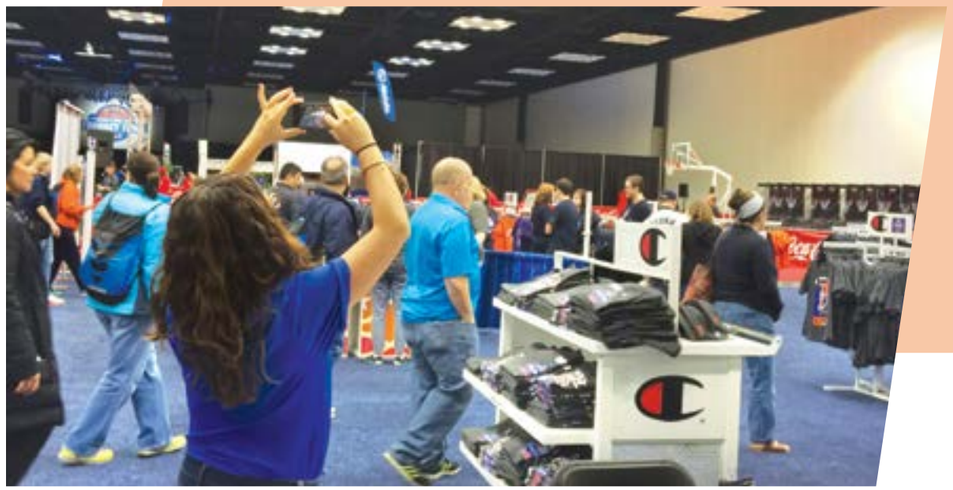
PURCHASING BEHAVIOR

Frank buys for himself and for those he knows. When buying for himself he looks for items that are more for memorabilia. He likes to get basketballs, banners and t-shirts. He also likes to collect lower cost items and spends a lot of time in the team autograph sessions. Frank also makes sure to buy for his friends and family. When he thinks about what to buy, he makes his decision based on the interest of those he buys for. This year he was buying his niece a nap sack because she enjoys outdoor activities and he felt that she would use it regularly. To get the items he is looking for, Frank will often go to the stores in each hotel, as well as Tourney Town, to see what items are available in each location.

SUGGESTIONS

Frank likes the items that are available at the locations. However, being from a large city he has trouble with the transit, he would like to have smoother service when wanting to go outside the downtown area. Frank also would like to see more opportunities to meet teams from around the area. Since there are a lot of good college teams near the Final Four location he thinks it would be nice to meet some of those players, even though they did not make the tournament. Frank would like it if they brought back the nice photos of the teams so that players could sign next to their pictures. It would also be good if he didn't have to walk to every stand to see the different merchandise. Sometimes merchandise would be available at the hotel but not on display yet at Tourney Town.





Herron students conducting research at the JW Marriott and Tourney Town.



















EXPERIENCE FLOW

An **Experience Flow Map** illustrates the overall journey of the attendees while describing the activity and emotions throughout the event. Our design research team developed the map based on the interview data we gathered at the **2016 Women's Final Four** where we asked participants to describe their touchpoints in detail. Each touchpoint on the map highlights the pain points and insights the fans experienced during their journey between the various location of the **JW Marriott**, **Tourney Town**, and **Bankers Life Fieldhouse**.

The Overall Experience Flow map shows the fans' experiences from their decision to go to the Final Four event until they leave. While the Purchasing Opportunity map provides a zoom in description of the purchasing behavior, decisions, and motivations.

DECISION TO GO

Action

ANNUAL EVENT

- No matter which teams are playing or which city, fans use the opportunity to make it a reunion weekend. Each friend completes a job in the planning process
- Fans purchase tickets before knowing which teams will be represented and would come even if favorite team is not represented
- Some colleges pay for their coaches to attend the event recreationally

TOURNAMENT OR CONFERENCE

- Coach signed team up for middle school basketball tournament
- Conferences bring fans to Final Four event not just the event itself

NETWORK OR PROFFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Coaches want to connnect and network during coaching conferences
- Coaches want to meet the Final four coaches for professional development

Object

PAINTPOINTS: TECHNOLOGY

- Some elderly fans are limited in purchasing tickets and traveling due to their limitations with technology
- If a group of elderly people do not use smart phones or internet and need tickets it makes it difficult for family member
- The billing address and the shipping address currently have to match when purchasing making it difficult for family members to help their elderly family recieve their tickets without physically delivering them

Feeling

LOVE OF BASKETBALL

- Local fans attend event to support their city and their love for the sport
- In some fans opionions, March Madness is more popular than the NBA or professional basketball season
- Some lifelong atheletes feel that it is important to give back to the sports community.

TEAM LOYALTY

- The location of the tournament is not a deciding factor. Fans are motivated by the opportunity to support their team

TRAVEL

Action

COMPANIONSHIP

- Fans travel with family and/or friends or meet from at event from different cities
- Some fans meet local friends in the city to help with navigation around city

Feeling

CONVENIENCE

- Likes direct flights into destination cities & not paying additional funds for checked luggage

FEELING

PAIN POINT: WAYFINDING
- Better wayfinding system to help navigate people from the different events being held in Bankers Life, Convention Center, and hotels

EXCITEMENT UPON ARRIVAL
- Very excited to be at NCAA Final Four event and attend games
- Many people are excited when they arrive for the event activities and free merchandise

SPACE LAYOUT
BL TT
- Bankers Life has limited space inside store makes it crowded when a large amount of people are shopping
- The large space and quantity of merch at Tourney Town draws people in to explore what the store has to offer and has a better layout design than the other booths

TT
- The booth location was easy to find, adding to positive fan experience
- Customers like store setups where they can quickly get an overview of the available selection
- Prefer more space and less crowd when they are shopping

PAIN POINT: MERCHANDISE DISPLAY
JW
- Merchandise should be all out and visible as soon as booth opens to lessen frustrations
- There are no mirrors at booths or display stands for quick selection items such as hats

MERCHANDISE DISPLAY
TT
- Merchandise segmentation is helpful for navigating the booth (Men vs. Women)
- The long table display seems comfortable for multiple fans to interact with the merch

JW
- Some customers do not like to browse, choosing instead to get in and out quickly
- Prefers to have a variety of color in all areas when shopping

MATERIAL PREFERENCES
- Many customers do not like dri-fit material because it is too clingy
- Some customers likes shirts to feel nice, be loose, and fit over teir hips, likes athletic material over cotton because cotton shrinks

PAIN POINTS: AVAILABLE SELECTION
- No D2 or D3 shirts available for customers to purchase, customers were disappointed
- The display for smaller items such as teddy bears and magnets was difficult to see
- Too many grey item this year, some want to have more varieties of color
- Younger fans didn't see youth sizes represented hindering thier purchase
- Not all color and material combinations were represented

MERCHANDISE SELECTION: QUALITY
- Young customers prefer design over material and think about what they can wear with leggins or jeans when selecting a shirt
- Young girls like when the colors of the merch matches their High School
- Male customer purchases based on quality of material of shirt, sometimes price point is a concern if it doesn't match the quality
- Customers value quality and think good brand means good quality

MERCHANDISE SELECTION: COLOR
- Fans purchase shirts to exercise in and therefore doesn't purchase white shirts because they'll stain
- Some customers thought this year's 2016 final four logo's colors represented some of the teams represented in championship like Syracuse and Washington (orange and purple)
- Color and pattern are some of the top things fan use when considering what merch. to buy. Teams are also a big factor
- Purchases neurtal colored merch like grey, when favorite team is not represented in championship

PAIN POINT: CHECKOUT & PRICE
BL
- Customers look confused as to where checkout station
- The prices represented are too expensive for people on a budget

PRICE
- Local fan purchases some items but prefers to wait and get free merch during events
- The price is important factor in purchase decisions making
- Customers will spend more money to purchase team specific merhandise prior to event versus Final Four appairal at event

SIMPLE TRANSACTIONS
- Simple transaction process provides enjoyable experience for customers

INTERACTION

PAIN POINT: TOURIST RESOURCES
- Volunteers lack appropriate training to assist visitors with relevant information causing fans to get impatient or frustrated
- Fans always ask about what to see, where to eat. Volunteers or handouts should be tailored to the city to help guide fans.

SALES TEAM
BL
- People ask sales team about other merch stores in Banker's Life to see if they have more options
- Most customers did not interact with sales team while looking at the merch, but had good experiences with them at checkout

SEEKING ADVICE
- Customers seek friends and family advice while trying on clothes, and also use their help to check sizes
- When parents buy for their children who are not present, they text pictures of merchandise for children to make the decision

PAIN POINTS: PRICE
- High school customers avoid telling parents price of items because the merch is too expensive
- Young customers are limited by how much money they were given by their parents
- Programs are too expensive and not functional after tournament

SEEKING ADVICE OR APPROVAL
- Will ask friends for advice on what to purchase
- Parents seek approval from children before purchase

PAIN POINT: VOLUNTEERS
- Volunteers lack appropriate training for sales (fumble check-out transaction that irritate fan)

SALES TRANSACTION
- Flexibility of checkout stations helps effeciency of customer purchasing process
- Friendly staff make overall experience more enjoyable
- Instant gratification is important to fans
- Having multiple staff memebers at checkout made the purchasing process easy and painless

OBJECT

FREE COFFEE
JW
- Fan thought Free coffee might be good as an attraction point to booth

ADDITIONAL ITEMS
- Some high school customers think they would be able to get more items if they shop with their mom in order to have more access to funds
- Younger fans would like to see running shorts, leggings, and crew neck sweatshirts
- Exlusive items to location draw customers' attention
- Additional product suggestions: Sweat bands, Women's hair ties, small towels for gym
- When buying gifts for friends the merchandise could be non-basketball related
- Wants to have Final 4 team names on the basketball

PAIN POINT: KID MERCHANDISE
- Not many items for kids

MOTIVATION FOR PURCHASE

EARLY SHOPPERS
- Customer come to the merch stores early when the arrive to event to ensure they get the proper sizes and items before they run out

PRICE
- Customer does not like white shirts typically, but purchased one because it was less expensive
- Small items that can be used as a memento are popular because they are the least expensive

PURPOSE
- Customers purchase items to accommedate appropriate local weather conditions
- Fans buy merch. with future use in mind. (for ex. Hats for when playing golf…)
- Fans purchase items to get autographed

COLLECTION
- Fans buy merch. in order to continue collection (Always buy Final Four shirts)
- Collecting is a big reason of buying. Some merchandise is exclusively bought for collection, not for wear
- Some collect tees with final 4 teams every year to see how teams change.

MEMENTO FOR OTHERS
- Customer always tries to bring back an assortment of novelties for people to choose from back home
- Many fans buy gifts for friends. Some gifts may be requested while others are bought because the person thought the friend would enjoy the merchandise.

MOMENTO FOR SELF
- Purchases because it brings back memories of the year they went with friends and family and is a nice momento
- Some fans look for small mementos to take home (pins)
- Despite existing shirts, customer wants a shirt with all four teams represented from this year
- Fan likes to wear merchandise from previous championsips instead of the new purchases from this event

TEAM SUPPORT
- Purchases favoite team's merch to wear when in new city for familiarity and to identify other supportive fans as a conversation starter
- Color and pattern are some of the top things fan use when considering what merch. to buy. Teams are also a big factor.

Pain Point Summary

LIMITATIONS

- Some elderly fans are limited in purchasing tickets and traveling due to their limitations with technology. If a group of elderly people do not use smart phones or internet and need tickets it makes it difficult for their support system
- The billing address and the shipping address currently have to match when purchasing making it difficult for family members to help their elderly family receive their tickets without physically delivering them
- Grade-school fans have a difficult time attending championships because of school and most games are during the week

TOURIST RESOURCES

- Information about the local city was not provided
- Out of town guests had limited public transportation to navigate around city
- Having a map and location indicator on the fan guide would help give fans an idea of the vicinity of events
- Many people were unaware of additional events going on like Tourney Town
- Better way-finding system to help navigate people from the different events being held in Bankers Life, Convention Center, and hotels
- Volunteers lack appropriate training to assist visitors with relevant information causing fans to get impatient or frustrated
- Fans always ask about what to see, where to eat. Volunteers or handouts should be tailored to the city to help guide fans.

MERCHANDISE DISPLAY

- Merchandise should be all out and visible as soon as booth opens to lessen frustrations
- There are no mirrors at booths or display stands for quick selection items such as hats
- The display for smaller items such as teddy bears and magnets was difficult to see

MERCHANDISE SELECTION

- Too many gray item this year, some want to have more varieties of color
- Younger fans didn't see youth sizes represented hindering their purchase
- Not all color and material combinations were represented
- Not many items for kids
- No D2 or D3 shirts available for customers to purchase, customers were disappointed
- Disparity between Men's and Women's Final Four merchandise availability

PRICE

- The prices represented are too expensive for people on a budget
- High school customers avoid telling parents price of items because the merchandise is too expensive
- Young customers are limited by how much money they were given by their parents
- Programs are too expensive and not functional after tournament

CHECKOUT PROCESS

- In Bankers Life store, customers have to wait in long lines with very limited space when the store is crowded
- Customers look confused as to where checkout station are in Bankers Life store

Summary of Ideas

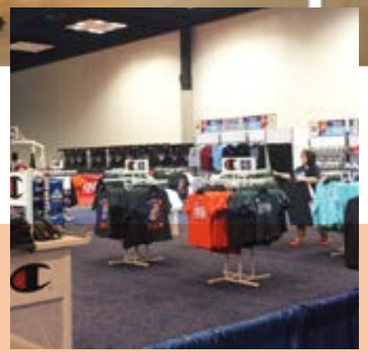
MERCHANDISE

- Customers would like to see varied price point items, specifically lower entry-level priced items
- Youth sizing should be more prevalent due to the large age of middle school aged girls
- Understanding the purchase motive between a memento for personal sentiment or a gift for a loved one
- More access to all products online and styles from previous years (attention to previous year item trends)
- Awareness of items at each location for customers convenience
- More options for smaller merchandise items for collectors

RESOURCES

- Incorporating local city culture into merchandise to customize fan's experience
- More tourist and event resources are needed regarding city information and transportation
- Improved volunteer training
- Advertising of events















FINDING OPPORTUNITIES

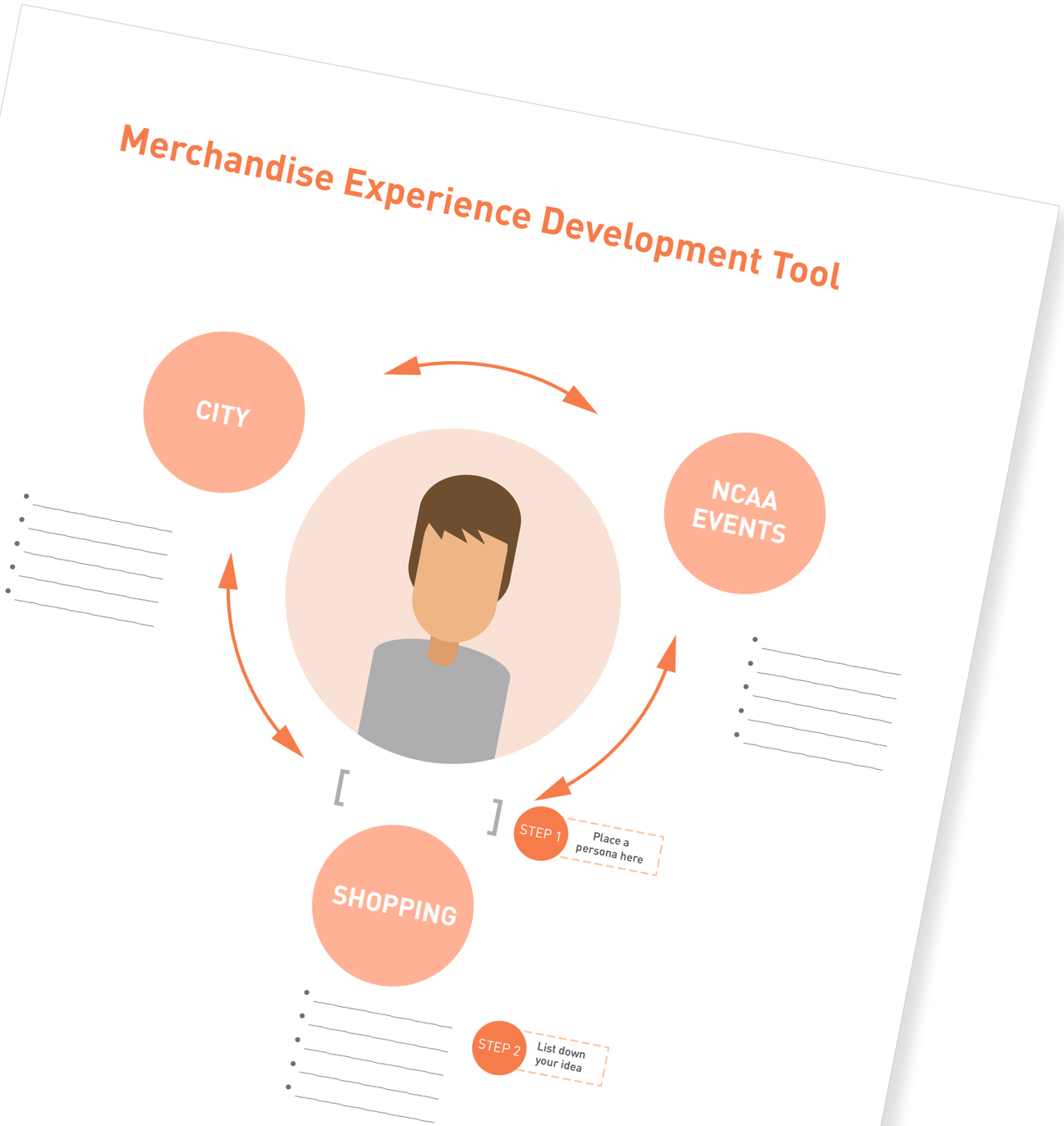
Using the developed Personas and Experience Flow Maps, we synthesized the major insights and pain points from the overall Final Four experience. We took the problem areas and created a opportunity statement to help reframe pain points into opportunities for your next steps.

To create a challenge statement, we use the beginning phrase of How Might We or (HMW). How Might We statements is a method used to transition problems areas into areas for opportunity. By developing the HMW statement, we were able to expand the merchandise experience to include the overall event experience. We identified three major opportunity spaces to develop solutions in your next steps; the local **City**, their experience at **NCAA Events**, and their experience while **Shopping**.

HOW MIGHT WE

enhance the merchandise experience by connecting the overall event experience?

(City, NCAA Event, Shopping)

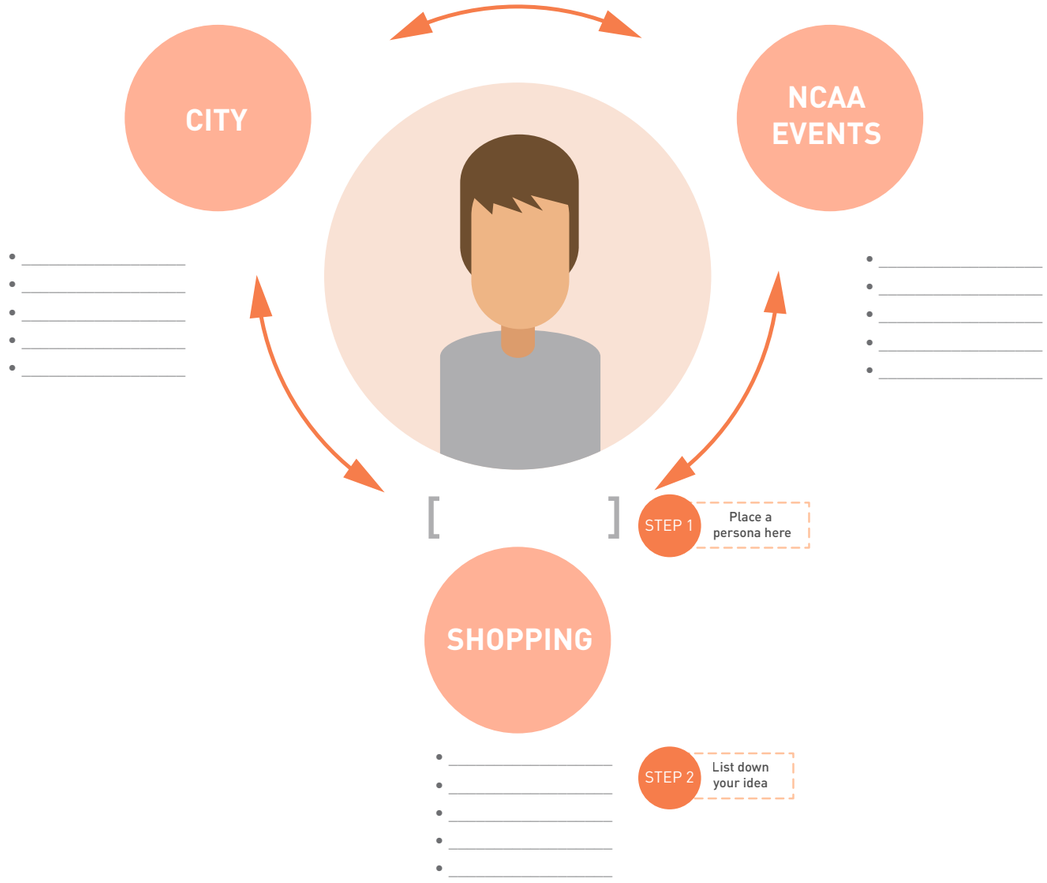


IDEATION TOOL

Using our methodology, the next step following a HMW statement would be Ideation or generating ideas that answers the challenge statement. Our ultimate goal of this research project was to provide a holistic understanding of the fans that purchase merchandise. In addition, our design research team designed a tool **to facilitate people-centered ideation based on the insights from the developed Personas and Experience Flow Maps**.

Each step of the tool has clear instructions to result in appropriate ideas starting with a defined persona profile. We have also provided people-centered criteria to consider to help evaluate ideas more strategically. Knowing your assets, you can elaborate on criteria that directly depends on the execution and feasibility of the ideas generated. This tool is for use with any of the events the NCAA develops for Championships.

Merchandise Experience Development Tool



Instructions

Step.1 Select a persona. Look at their background, purchase behaviors, and suggestions (Refer to pages 38-41)

Step.2 Generate ideas for possible solutions according to the selected persona's pain points

Shopping experience

* Service: Involves touchpoints with NCAA's merchandise and Event One employees
* Products: Merchandise options to meet various consumers' interest

NCAA events experience

* Spectatorship: In involves attendees' every interaction points with NCAA from the beginning to the end
* Connection with others: To interact with others that share the moment, interest or mentality
* Fan-oriented entertainment: Experiencing the moment which honors or corresponds attendee's passion to the basketball or the team

City experience

* Infrastructure: To support attendees' necessary activities during the participation of the event
* Empowerment: To enhance attendees' ownership of actions and decision making
* Recreational entertainment: Social activities for the general public other than NCAA events

Step.3 Use following suggested criteria or your own to evaluate all the ideas

* Affordability
* Community involvement
* Attracting younger fan base
* Transferable between cities
* _____ (create your own)
* _____ (create your own)
* _____ (create your own)
* _____ (create your own)





CONCLUSION

From our research, the design team was able to identify strategic goals that focus on customers perspectives. The **Personas** and **Experience Flow Maps** provide a framework for understanding the fan beyond a consumer perspective. These tools allow for a holistic understanding of the fan's experience, not only through merchandise, but from their overall Championship experience including pain points that exist within the current service model. The insights generated from this research can be used to develop strategic solutions that improve the overall merchandise experience by connecting the overall event experience by leveraging the local city and shopping opportunities for Championship attendees.

To provide a base for moving forward for future service solutions, we provided an Ideation Tool to help generate appropriate solutions reflecting the insights from the fan participants. The tool provides an instructional system to formulate solutions based on the fan's contextual needs and currently observed pain points. Starting with a defined fan profile and his or her needs, it provides a structure to relate those needs to strategic goals. The 3 step process outlined in the toolkit will allow for the comprehensive evaluation of future developments and allow for in depth evaluation of future services and strategies across all sports.

©Herron School of Art and Design, Indiana University

Without limiting the rights under copyright reserved above, no part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in, or introduced into a retrieval system, or transmitted, in any form or by any means (electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise) without the prior written permission of the copyright owner listed above.